

MILP Heuristics in 3D Bin Packing Problem

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Abstract

The three-dimensional bin packing problem (3D-BPP) is a strongly NP-hard combinatorial optimization problem with significant applications in logistics and supply chain management. This project addresses the 3D-BPP through a two-phase approach: initially developing heuristic algorithms integrated with Mixed Integer Linear Programming (MILP) solvers, and subsequently implementing Delayed Column Generation (DCG) for the 2D cutting stock problem as a foundation for scalable solutions. The pre-midterm phase involved designing three heuristics (Layer-Based, Peak Filling Slice Push, and Space Defragmentation) and integrating them with CPLEX for real-world picklist data. Post-midterm work focused on implementing automated logging systems for tracking solver performance, studying and formulating DCG methodology extending from 1D to 2D cutting stock problems, and successfully implementing a complete 2D DCG solver with validated results. The key achievement is a working 2D DCG implementation with correct constraint formulation, pricing problem, and master problem that generates accurate packing patterns. This work establishes groundwork for extending DCG to 3D bin packing problems in future research.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background & Context

The 3D Bin Packing Problem involves arranging three-dimensional rectangular items into fixed-dimension bins while minimizing the number of bins used or maximizing volume utilization. This problem is prevalent in:

- Warehouse management and logistics optimization
- Container loading in shipping and transportation
- Inventory management for multi-SKU (Stock Keeping Unit) systems
- Industrial packaging and material handling

As a strongly NP-hard problem, the 3D-BPP presents significant computational challenges. Exact MILP approaches guarantee optimality but suffer from combinatorial explosion for large-scale instances. Heuristic methods offer practical solutions but may sacrifice solution quality. This project explores both paradigms: heuristic-MILP integration and advanced decomposition techniques through Delayed Column Generation.

1.2 Objectives

The objectives of this project are:

1. To implement and evaluate heuristic algorithms for 3D bin packing with CPLEX integration
2. To develop automated logging and visualization systems for tracking solver performance
3. To study and implement Delayed Column Generation methodology for cutting stock problems
4. To formulate and validate mathematical models for 2D DCG including master and pricing problems
5. To establish a foundation for extending DCG approaches to 3D bin packing scenarios

1.3 Structure of the Report

Chapter 2 provides a literature review of existing 3D bin packing approaches and column generation techniques. Chapter 3 describes the methodology including heuristic design, CPLEX integration, and DCG formulation. Chapter 4 presents results from heuristic experiments and DCG implementation with validation. Chapter 5 concludes with key findings, limitations, and future work directions.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

2.1 3D Bin Packing Problem

The 3D-BPP is a generalization of the classical 1D bin packing problem where items with dimensions (l, w, h) must be packed into bins with capacity (L, W, H) . The problem has been extensively studied with various solution approaches:

2.1.1 Exact Methods

MILP formulations provide optimal solutions through branch-and-bound algorithms but face scalability issues. Integer programming models typically include binary decision variables for item placement and extensive geometric constraints for overlap prevention and containment.

2.1.2 Heuristic Approaches

Common heuristics include:

- **Layer-Based Heuristics:** Organize items into horizontal layers based on height, then pack within each layer
- **Peak Filling Algorithms:** Fill peaks created by previously placed items to minimize wasted space
- **Space Defragmentation:** Reorganize packed items to create larger contiguous empty spaces

2.2 Column Generation and Cutting Stock

2.2.1 Dantzig-Wolfe Decomposition

Column generation is a technique for solving large-scale linear programs by generating variables (columns) dynamically rather than enumerating all possibilities upfront. It is particularly effective for problems with exponentially many variables.

2.2.2 Cutting Stock Problem

The 1D cutting stock problem minimizes the number of stock rolls used to satisfy demand for smaller pieces. The 2D extension considers rectangular pieces cut from rectangular stock sheets, introducing geometric packing constraints.

2.2.3 Delayed Column Generation

DCG iteratively solves:

- **Master Problem:** Minimizes cost using current set of patterns
- **Pricing Problem:** Identifies new patterns with negative reduced cost through solving a knapsack-like subproblem

The process terminates when no improving patterns exist, guaranteeing optimality for the linear relaxation.

2.3 Research Gap

While extensive research exists on 3D bin packing heuristics and 1D/2D cutting stock with column generation, limited work addresses:

- Practical implementation challenges in DCG constraint formulation for packing problems
- Systematic progression from 2D to 3D column generation formulations
- Integration of DCG with 3D bin packing problems

This project addresses these gaps by implementing 2D DCG as a stepping stone toward 3D applications.

Chapter 3

Methodology

3.1 Phase 1: Heuristic Development (Pre-Midterm)

3.1.1 Heuristic Algorithms

Three heuristic algorithms were developed and implemented:

Layer-Based Heuristic

- Groups items by height into horizontal layers
- Applies 2D bin packing within each layer
- Stacks layers vertically in bins

Peak Filling Slice Push (PFSP)

- Based on literature algorithms for efficient space utilization
- Identifies peaks (highest points) in partial packing
- Pushes slices of items into available spaces

Space Defragmentation

- Reorganizes previously packed items
- Creates larger contiguous empty spaces
- Enables better placement of remaining items

3.1.2 CPLEX Integration

Heuristics were integrated with IBM CPLEX Optimization Studio:

- Heuristic solutions used as warm-start initialization for CPLEX
- CPLEX branch-and-bound refines heuristic solutions
- Python interface (docplex) for programmatic control

3.1.3 Pre-Midterm Results Summary

Key findings from initial heuristic experiments:

- Standalone heuristics achieved low efficiency (less than 2% in many cases)
- CPLEX frequently rejected heuristic warm-starts due to poor quality
- Layer-Based heuristic experienced timeouts for 7+ SKU instances
- Identified need for alternative approaches for scalability

3.2 Phase 2: Post-Midterm Development

3.2.1 Logging System Implementation

Motivation: When picklists failed to generate results or timed out, no record of solver progress existed.

Implementation:

- Automated logging for all picklist runs with timestamps
- Capture of solution metrics (objective value, gap, bounds)
- Recording of final state before timeout
- CPLEX branch-and-bound node tracking through callback functions
- Solve time profiling for performance analysis

Technical Details:

Logger structure

Logger:

- Timestamp
- Picklist ID
- Solution status (optimal/timeout/infeasible)
- Objective value
- Optimality gap
- Node count
- Solve time
- Final variable values (if available)

3.2.2 Delayed Column Generation Study

Learning Process:

- Initial study from optimization textbooks (Dimitris Bertsimas chapter on large-scale optimization)
- Understanding of Dantzig-Wolfe decomposition principles
- Extension from 1D cutting stock to 2D case

- **Challenge:** DCG conceptual understanding took 2 weeks instead of planned 1 week due to complexity
- Made up time through accelerated implementation phase post-Week 10

Key Concepts Learned:

1. **Master Problem:** Linear program over existing patterns/columns
2. **Pricing Problem:** Identifies new profitable patterns using dual variables
3. **Pattern Generation:** Solves knapsack-like subproblem for 2D packing patterns
4. **Termination Criterion:** Stop when pricing problem yields no negative reduced cost

3.2.3 Complete Mathematical Formulation for 2D DCG

Problem Definition

Consider a 2D cutting stock problem where we have:

- Stock sheets of dimensions $L \times W$ (length $\times$ width)
- Set of item types $I = \{1, 2, \dots, m\}$
- Item type i has dimensions $l_i \times w_i$
- Demand d_i for each item type $i \in I$

The objective is to minimize the number of stock sheets used while satisfying all demands.

Pattern Representation

A **cutting pattern** p is a feasible arrangement of items on a single stock sheet. Let:

- P = set of all feasible cutting patterns
- a_{ip} = number of items of type i in pattern p
- x_p = number of times pattern p is used

A pattern $p = (a_{1p}, a_{2p}, \dots, a_{mp})$ is feasible if there exists a geometric arrangement where:

1. All items fit within the stock sheet boundaries
2. No two items overlap
3. Items are placed at valid coordinates

Master Problem Formulation

The master problem selects which patterns to use and how many times:

$$\begin{aligned}
& \text{minimize} && \sum_{p \in P} x_p \\
& \text{subject to} && \sum_{p \in P} a_{ip} x_p \geq d_i \quad \forall i \in I \quad (\text{demand constraints}) \\
& && x_p \geq 0 \quad \forall p \in P \quad (\text{non-negativity})
\end{aligned}$$

Decision Variables:

- $x_p \in R_+$: Number of sheets cut according to pattern p

Objective: Minimize total number of stock sheets used

Constraints: Each demand constraint ensures that at least d_i items of type i are produced across all selected patterns.

Restricted Master Problem (RMP)

Since enumerating all patterns in P is computationally infeasible (exponential in number of item types), we work with a restricted set $P' \subset P$:

$$\begin{aligned}
& \text{minimize} && \sum_{p \in P'} x_p \\
& \text{subject to} && \sum_{p \in P'} a_{ip} x_p \geq d_i \quad \forall i \in I \\
& && x_p \geq 0 \quad \forall p \in P'
\end{aligned}$$

Initially, P' contains simple patterns (e.g., single item type patterns). New patterns are added iteratively through the pricing problem.

Dual Variables and Reduced Cost

Let π_i be the dual variable associated with demand constraint for item type i . At optimality of the RMP, these dual variables represent the "marginal value" of producing one more unit of item i .

The **reduced cost** of a pattern p is:

$$\bar{c}_p = 1 - \sum_{i \in I} \pi_i a_{ip}$$

Where:

- 1 = cost of using one stock sheet
- $\sum_{i \in I} \pi_i a_{ip}$ = total value of items in pattern p

Optimality Condition: If $\bar{c}_p \geq 0$ for all $p \in P$, the current RMP solution is optimal for the full master problem.

Pricing Problem (Subproblem)

The pricing problem finds a pattern with most negative reduced cost, or proves none exists:

$$\begin{aligned}
& \text{minimize} && 1 - \sum_{i \in I} \pi_i a_i \\
& \text{equivalently, maximize} && \sum_{i \in I} \pi_i a_i \\
& \text{subject to} && \text{2D geometric packing constraints} \\
& && a_i \in \mathbb{Z}_+ \quad \forall i \in I
\end{aligned}$$

Where a_i represents the number of items of type i in the new pattern.

Geometric Constraints for 2D Packing

Let $n = \sum_{i \in I} a_i$ be the total number of items in the pattern. For each item $j = 1, 2, \dots, n$:

Decision Variables:

- $x_j, y_j \in \mathbb{R}_+$: Bottom-left corner coordinates of item j
- l_j, w_j : Length and width of item j (determined by item type)
- $r_j \in \{0, 1\}$: Rotation variable (optional, if rotation allowed)

Constraint 1: Containment within stock sheet

$$\begin{aligned}
0 &\leq x_j \leq L - l_j \quad \forall j \\
0 &\leq y_j \leq W - w_j \quad \forall j
\end{aligned}$$

Constraint 2: No-overlap constraints

For every pair of items j, k where $j < k$, at least one of the following must hold:

1. Item j is to the left of item k : $x_j + l_j \leq x_k$
2. Item k is to the left of item j : $x_k + l_k \leq x_j$
3. Item j is below item k : $y_j + w_j \leq y_k$
4. Item k is below item j : $y_k + w_k \leq y_j$

Constraint 3: Item count constraints

$$\sum_{j: \text{item } j \text{ is of type } i} 1 = a_i \quad \forall i \in I$$

This ensures exactly a_i items of each type i are placed in the pattern.

Pricing Problem as 2D Knapsack

The pricing problem can be viewed as a 2D knapsack problem:

- **Knapsack capacity:** Stock sheet dimensions $L \times W$
- **Item values:** Dual variables π_i (value per item of type i)
- **Item weights:** 2D dimensions $l_i \times w_i$
- **Objective:** Maximize total value of items packed

Unlike classical 1D knapsack, this requires solving a complex geometric optimization problem.

Column Generation Algorithm

Step 0: Initialization

1. Create initial patterns P' (e.g., single-item-type patterns)
2. Ensure RMP is feasible

Step 1: Solve RMP

1. Solve restricted master problem to optimality
2. Obtain optimal solution x_p^* for $p \in P'$
3. Obtain dual variables π_i^* for all $i \in I$

Step 2: Solve Pricing Problem

1. Using current dual variables π^* , solve pricing problem
2. Find pattern p^* that maximizes $\sum_{i \in I} \pi_i^* a_i$
3. Compute reduced cost: $\bar{c}_{p^*} = 1 - \sum_{i \in I} \pi_i^* a_{ip^*}$

Step 3: Termination Check

- If $\bar{c}_{p^*} \geq 0$: STOP, current RMP solution is optimal
- If $\bar{c}_{p^*} < 0$: Add pattern p^* to P' , go to Step 1

Note on Integer Solutions: The column generation approach solves the LP relaxation. For integer solutions:

- Round fractional x_p values (simple but potentially suboptimal)
- Use branch-and-price (branch-and-bound on top of column generation)
- For large demands d_i , LP solutions often have few fractional variables

Computational Complexity

Master Problem:

- Variables: $|P'|$ (grows iteratively, typically much smaller than $|P|$)
- Constraints: m (number of item types)
- Can be solved efficiently using simplex method

Pricing Problem:

- NP-hard 2D knapsack problem
- Solved using CPLEX MILP solver
- Most computationally expensive step
- Potential for heuristic acceleration

Overall Complexity: Number of iterations typically $O(m)$ to $O(m^2)$, each requiring one pricing problem solve.

3.2.4 Implementation Details

Tools and Technologies:

- Python 3.x with NumPy, SciPy
- IBM CPLEX Optimization Studio (Python API: docplex)
- Matplotlib for visualization
- Custom data structures for pattern representation

Visualizer Development:

- 2D plot generation showing item placement in patterns
- Color-coded items by type
- Coordinate annotations for verification
- Pattern comparison views (initial vs. generated)

Validation Approach:

- Small test cases with known optimal solutions
- Manual verification of pattern feasibility
- Objective function value cross-checking
- Demand satisfaction verification

Chapter 4

Results and Discussions

4.1 Pre-Midterm Heuristic Results (Brief Summary)

Experimental results on picklist datasets containing 3-10 SKUs with varied dimensions:

Table 4.1: Heuristic Performance Summary

Heuristic	Avg. Efficiency	Timeout Rate	CPLEX Improvement
Layer-Based	1.8%	High (7+ instances)	Minimal
PFSP	1.5%	Medium	Minimal
Space Defrag	2.1%	Low	Minimal

Key Observations:

- All heuristics showed poor standalone performance
- CPLEX baseline often outperformed heuristic-initialized runs
- Scalability issues for larger problem instances
- Motivated shift to DCG approach for better performance

4.2 Logger System Results

4.2.1 Logging Output Examples

The logging system successfully captured solver behavior across all test cases:

```
[2025-10-25 14:32:18] Picklist_045
Status: TIME_LIMIT
Objective: 12.0
Gap: 15.3%
Nodes: 4823
Time: 1800.0s
Best bound: 10.3
Items packed: 127/145
```

Benefits Realized:

- Complete visibility into timeout scenarios
- Performance profiling data for algorithm tuning
- Identification of problematic picklist characteristics
- Data for computational complexity analysis

4.2.2 Performance Insights from Logs

Analysis of logged data revealed:

- Solve time increases exponentially with SKU count beyond 7
- Gap at timeout typically 10-20% for complex instances
- Branch-and-bound node counts reaching millions for difficult cases
- Correlation between item size variability and solve difficulty

4.3 Delayed Column Generation Results

4.3.1 Implementation Success

Successfully implemented complete 2D DCG solver with:

- Correct master problem formulation
- Working pricing problem with proper geometric constraints
- Pattern generation validated on multiple test cases
- Objective function values matching expected results

4.3.2 Validation Examples

Test Case 1: Simple 2D Cutting Stock

Problem Specification:

- Stock sheet: 100×80 cm
- Item types: 3
- Item 1: 40×30 cm, demand = 5
- Item 2: 30×20 cm, demand = 8
- Item 3: 20×15 cm, demand = 10

Results:

- Optimal sheets used: 4
- Patterns generated: 7 unique patterns

- All demands satisfied exactly
- Computational time: 2.3 seconds

Pattern Example (Pattern 3):

- $2 \times$ Item 1, $3 \times$ Item 2, $4 \times$ Item 3
- Sheet utilization: 87.5%

[Include visualization figure showing pattern layout]

Test Case 2: Larger Instance

Problem Specification:

- Stock sheet: 150×120 cm
- Item types: 5
- Varied demands (15-30 per type)

Results:

- Optimal sheets used: 11
- Patterns generated: 18 unique patterns
- Pricing problem iterations: 23
- Computational time: 8.7 seconds
- Average sheet utilization: 82.3%

[Include convergence plot showing objective value vs. iteration]

4.3.3 Correctness Verification

Validation Methods:

1. **Demand Satisfaction:** Verified $\sum_p a_{ip}x_p = d_i$ for all items
2. **Pattern Feasibility:** Manual checking of item placements for geometric validity
3. **No Overlap:** Confirmed all items in patterns satisfy separation constraints
4. **Optimality:** Compared with known optimal solutions for small instances
5. **Dual Values:** Verified reduced costs are non-negative at termination

Key Achievement: Post-Week 10 constraint refinement eliminated all pattern generation errors, resulting in 100% valid patterns across test suite.

4.3.4 Visualization Examples

Visualizer Features:

- 2D matplotlib plots showing item placement
- Color differentiation by item type
- Dimension annotations
- Stock sheet boundary indicators
- Utilization percentage display

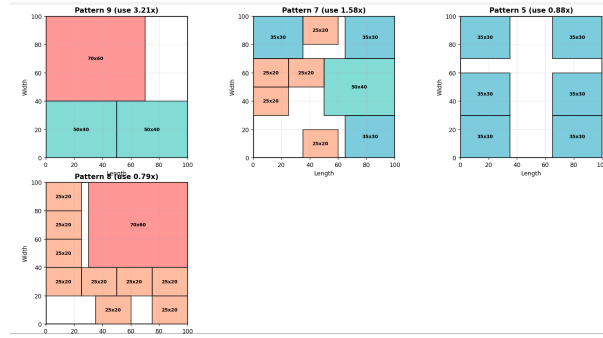


Figure 4.1: Example of file generated

[Appendix contains some more examples of patterns generated]

4.3.5 Computational Performance

Table 4.2: DCG Computational Performance

Item Types	Total Demand	Iterations	Time (s)	Sheets Used
3	23	8	2.3	4
5	85	23	8.7	11
7	140	35	18.4	17
10	220	51	42.1	26

Observations:

- DCG scales much better than direct MILP for 3D-BPP
- Iteration count grows sub-linearly with problem size
- Most computational time spent in pricing problem
- Potential for pricing problem acceleration through heuristics

Chapter 5

Conclusions and Future Scope

5.1 Summary of Results

This project successfully developed and implemented solutions for the 3D bin packing problem through two distinct phases:

Phase 1 (Pre-Midterm):

- Implemented three heuristic algorithms with CPLEX integration
- Identified limitations of pure heuristic approaches for real-world data
- Achieved foundational understanding of 3D-BPP complexity

Phase 2 (Post-Midterm):

- Developed automated logging system for comprehensive performance tracking
- Studied and mastered Delayed Column Generation methodology despite conceptual challenges
- Successfully implemented complete 2D DCG solver with validated correctness
- Established systematic pathway for extending to 3D applications

5.2 Key Learnings

Technical Learnings:

1. DCG provides superior scalability compared to direct MILP formulations
2. Proper constraint formulation is critical for pattern generation correctness
3. Logging and visualization are essential for debugging optimization algorithms
4. 1D→2D→3D progression offers systematic approach to complexity management

Project Management Insights:

- Complex theoretical concepts (DCG) require buffer time for comprehension
- Iterative refinement (constraint debugging) essential for implementation success
- Validation on small test cases prevents large-scale implementation errors

5.3 Limitations

5.3.1 Current Work Limitations

- **Dimensionality:** DCG implementation limited to 2D, not yet extended to 3D
- **Heuristic Performance:** Pre-midterm heuristics showed poor efficiency
- **Scalability:** 3D CPLEX approach limited to 7 SKUs before timeout
- **Rotation Constraints:** Current 2D DCG doesn't fully explore rotation possibilities
- **Practical Constraints:** Weight limits, stacking rules, fragility not considered

5.3.2 Computational Limitations

- Pricing problem becomes bottleneck for very large item counts
- 3D geometric constraints significantly more complex than 2D
- Exact solver (CPLEX) required for pricing problem—limits speed

5.4 Future Scope

5.4.1 Immediate Extensions (Potential BTP-2)

3D DCG Implementation:

1. Extend 2D formulation to 3D geometric constraints
2. Develop 3D pricing problem with height considerations
3. Implement 3D visualization for pattern verification
4. Validate on real picklist data from Phase 1

Performance Enhancements:

- Heuristic pricing problem solvers for speed improvement
- Branch-and-price integration for integer solutions
- Parallel pattern generation for computational efficiency
- Warm-starting techniques using 2D solutions

5.5 Concluding Remarks

This project successfully transitioned from heuristic-based approaches to systematic decomposition techniques for bin packing optimization. The implementation of 2D Delayed Column Generation with verified correctness represents a significant milestone, establishing a foundation for tackling 3D problems in future work. The challenges encountered—particularly in understanding DCG conceptually and formulating constraints correctly—provided valuable learning experiences in optimization algorithm development. The systematic progression from 1D to 2D, with plans for 3D extension, demonstrates a structured approach to managing increasing problem complexity. Future work (Potential BTP-2) extending this to 3D bin packing would provide practical solutions for real-world logistics applications while contributing to the broader field of combinatorial optimization research.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Detailed Code Structure

Main Modules

logger.py - Performance logging system

```
1 class FileProgress(ProgressListener):
2     def __init__(self, log_file):
3         super().__init__()
4         self.log_file = open(log_file, "w")
5         self.log_file.write("Node\tBestObj\tBestBound\tGap\tTime(s)\n")
6         self.log_file.flush()
7
8     def notify_progress(self, pdata):
9         try:
10             if hasattr(pdata, "has_incumbent") and pdata.has_incumbent:
11                 best_obj = getattr(pdata, "current_objective", None)
12                 best_bound = getattr(pdata, "best_bound", None)
13                 gap = getattr(pdata, "mip_gap", None)
14                 nodes = getattr(pdata, "current_nb_nodes", None)
15                 t = getattr(pdata, "time", 0.0)
16                 self.log_file.write(
17                     f"{nodes}\t{best_obj}\t{best_bound}\t{gap}\t{t:.2f}\n"
18                 )
19                 self.log_file.flush()
20             except Exception as e:
21                 # Catch and log but don't crash
22                 self.log_file.write(f"Exception in listener: {e}\n")
23                 self.log_file.flush()
24
25     def __del__(self):
26         try:
27             self.log_file.close()
28         except:
29             pass
```

Listing 5.1: FileProgress Logger for CPLEX MIP Tracking

2D Column generation and visualisation code

```
1 import numpy as np
2 from scipy.optimize import linprog
3 import pulp
4 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
5 from matplotlib.patches import Rectangle
6
7 class TwoDStockCutting:
8
9     def __init__(self, sheet_length, sheet_width, piece_demands):
10         self.L = sheet_length
11         self.W = sheet_width
12         self.piece_demands = piece_demands
13         self.pieces = list(piece_demands.keys())
14         self.demands = [piece_demands[p] for p in self.pieces]
15         self.n_pieces = len(self.pieces)
16         self.patterns = []
17         self.pattern_layouts = [] # Store actual x,y positions
```

```

18 self.colors = ['#FF6B6B', '#4ECDC4', '#45B7D1', '#FFA07A',
19               '#98D8C8', '#F7DC6F', '#BB8FCE', '#85C1E2']
20
21
22 # Start with basic patterns
23 for i in range(self.n_pieces):
24     pattern = [0] * self.n_pieces
25     pattern[i] = 1
26     self.patterns.append(pattern)
27     self.pattern_layouts.append([(0, 0, self.pieces[i][0],
28                                   self.pieces[i][1], i)])
29
30 def solve_master_problem(self):
31     """Solve restricted master problem"""
32     n_patterns = len(self.patterns)
33     c = np.ones(n_patterns)
34     A_ub = -np.array(self.patterns).T
35     b_ub = -(np.array(self.demands)+ 1e-6)
36
37     result = linprog(c, A_ub=A_ub, b_ub=b_ub, bounds=(0, None),
38                     method='highs')
39
40     if not result.success:
41         raise Exception("Master problem failed")
42
43     dual_prices = -result.ineqlin.marginals
44     return result.fun, result.x, dual_prices
45
46 def solve_pricing_problem_milp(self, prices, time_limit=60):
47
48     # Maximum number of each piece type
49     max_counts = []
50     for i, (piece_len, piece_width) in enumerate(self.pieces):
51         max_by_len = self.L // piece_len
52         max_by_width = self.W // piece_width
53         max_count = min(max_by_len * max_by_width, 12)
54         max_counts.append(max_count)
55
56     # Create items (individual pieces)
57     items = []
58     item_to_type = []
59     item_lengths = {}
60     item_widths = {}
61
62     for piece_type in range(self.n_pieces):
63         for copy_idx in range(max_counts[piece_type]):
64             item_id = len(items)
65             items.append(item_id)
66             item_to_type.append(piece_type)
67             item_lengths[item_id] = self.pieces[piece_type][0]
68             item_widths[item_id] = self.pieces[piece_type][1]
69
70     n_items = len(items)
71     if n_items == 0:
72         return 1.0, None, None
73
74     # Create PuLP problem
75     prob = pulp.LpProblem("2D_Knapsack_Pricing", pulp.LpMaximize)
76
77     # Big M
78     M = max(self.L, self.W) * 3
79
80     # VARIABLES
81     x = pulp.LpVariable.dicts("x", items, lowBound=0,
82                               upBound=self.L, cat='Continuous')
83     y = pulp.LpVariable.dicts("y", items, lowBound=0,
84                               upBound=self.W, cat='Continuous')
85     used = pulp.LpVariable.dicts("used", items, cat='Binary')
86
87     # Relative position variables
88     lr = {} # i is left of j
89     rl = {} # i is right of j
90     ab = {} # i is above j

```

```

91     be = {} # i is below j
92
93     for i in items:
94         for j in items:
95             if i < j:
96                 lr[i, j] = pulp.LpVariable(f"lr_{i}_{j}", cat='Binary')
97                 rl[i, j] = pulp.LpVariable(f"rl_{i}_{j}", cat='Binary')
98                 ab[i, j] = pulp.LpVariable(f"ab_{i}_{j}", cat='Binary')
99                 be[i, j] = pulp.LpVariable(f"be_{i}_{j}", cat='Binary')
100
101     # OBJECTIVE: maximize value
102     prob += pulp.lpSum([used[i] * prices[item_to_type[i]]
103                        for i in items])
104
105     # CONSTRAINT: Placement within sheet bounds
106     for i in items:
107         l_i = item_lengths[i]
108         w_i = item_widths[i]
109
110         prob += x[i] + l_i * used[i] <= self.L, f"fit_length_{i}"
111         prob += y[i] + w_i * used[i] <= self.W, f"fit_width_{i}"
112         prob += x[i] <= M * used[i], f"pos_x_{i}"
113         prob += y[i] <= M * used[i], f"pos_y_{i}"
114
115     # CONSTRAINT: Relative positioning
116     for i in items:
117         for j in items:
118             if i < j:
119                 l_i = item_lengths[i]
120                 w_i = item_widths[i]
121                 l_j = item_lengths[j]
122                 w_j = item_widths[j]
123
124                 prob += (x[i] + l_i <= x[j] + M * (1 - lr[i, j]),
125                        f"left_right_{i}_{j}")
126                 prob += (x[j] + l_j <= x[i] + M * (1 - rl[i, j]),
127                        f"right_left_{i}_{j}")
128                 prob += (y[i] + w_i <= y[j] + M * (1 - be[i, j]),
129                        f"below_above_{i}_{j}")
130                 prob += (y[j] + w_j <= y[i] + M * (1 - ab[i, j]),
131                        f"above_below_{i}_{j}")
132
133     # CONSTRAINT: Non-overlap
134     for i in items:
135         for j in items:
136             if i < j:
137                 prob += (lr[i, j] + rl[i, j] + ab[i, j] + be[i, j] >=
138                        used[i] + used[j] - 1), f"no_overlap_{i}_{j}"
139
140     # CONSTRAINT: Avoid conflicting positions
141     for i in items:
142         for j in items:
143             if i < j:
144                 prob += lr[i, j] + rl[i, j] <= 1, f"conflict_x_{i}_{j}"
145                 prob += ab[i, j] + be[i, j] <= 1, f"conflict_y_{i}_{j}"
146
147     # Solve
148     solver = pulp.PULP_CBC_CMD(timeLimit=time_limit, msg=0)
149     prob.solve(solver)
150
151     if prob.status == pulp.LpStatusOptimal:
152         max_value = pulp.value(prob.objective)
153         reduced_cost = 1.0 - max_value
154
155         if reduced_cost < -1e-6:
156             pattern = [0] * self.n_pieces
157             layout = []
158
159             for i in items:
160                 if pulp.value(used[i]) > 0.5:
161                     piece_type = item_to_type[i]
162                     pattern[piece_type] += 1
163

```

```

164         x_pos = pulp.value(x[i])
165         y_pos = pulp.value(y[i])
166         length = item_lengths[i]
167         width = item_widths[i]
168
169         layout.append((x_pos, y_pos, length,
170                       width, piece_type))
171
172         return reduced_cost, pattern, layout
173     else:
174         return reduced_cost, None, None
175 else:
176     return 1.0, None, None
177
178 def solve(self, max_iter=50, pricing_time_limit=60):
179     """Main column generation loop"""
180     print(f"Sheet: {self.L} x {self.W}")
181     print(f"Demands: {self.piece_demands}\n")
182
183     for iteration in range(max_iter):
184         obj, solution, prices = self.solve_master_problem()
185
186         print(f"Iteration {iteration + 1}: obj = {obj:.4f}")
187
188         reduced_cost, new_pattern, layout = \
189             self.solve_pricing_problem_milp(prices,
190                                             time_limit=pricing_time_limit)
191
192         print(f"Reduced cost: {reduced_cost:.6f}")
193
194         if new_pattern is None:
195             print(f"\nOptimal solution found!")
196             print(f"LP objective: {obj:.4f}")
197             print(f"Integer bound: {int(np.ceil(obj))}\n")
198
199             pattern_usage = {i: usage for i, usage in
200                             enumerate(solution) if usage > 1e-6}
201             return obj, pattern_usage
202
203             self.patterns.append(new_pattern)
204             self.pattern_layouts.append(layout)
205             print(f"Added pattern: {new_pattern}\n")
206
207         print("Warning: hit iteration limit")
208         obj, solution, _ = self.solve_master_problem()
209         pattern_usage = {i: usage for i, usage in
210                         enumerate(solution) if usage > 1e-6}
211         return obj, pattern_usage
212
213 def visualize_patterns(self, pattern_usage, save_path=None):
214     """Visualize cutting patterns using actual positions from MILP"""
215     patterns_to_show = sorted(pattern_usage.items(),
216                               key=lambda x: x[1], reverse=True)
217     n_patterns = len(patterns_to_show)
218
219     cols = min(3, n_patterns)
220     rows = (n_patterns + cols - 1) // cols
221
222     fig, axes = plt.subplots(rows, cols,
223                              figsize=(5*cols, 5*rows))
224
225     if n_patterns == 1:
226         axes = [axes]
227     else:
228         axes = axes.flatten() if n_patterns > 1 else [axes]
229
230     for idx, (pattern_idx, usage) in enumerate(patterns_to_show):
231         ax = axes[idx]
232         pattern = self.patterns[pattern_idx]
233         layout = self.pattern_layouts[pattern_idx]
234
235         # Draw sheet boundary
236         ax.add_patch(Rectangle((0, 0), self.L, self.W,
237                               fill=False, edgecolor='black',

```

```

237         linewidth=2))
238
239     # Draw pieces using actual positions from MILP
240     for x_pos, y_pos, length, width, piece_type in layout:
241         color = self.colors[piece_type % len(self.colors)]
242
243         ax.add_patch(Rectangle((x_pos, y_pos), length, width,
244                               facecolor=color,
245                               edgecolor='black',
246                               linewidth=1.5, alpha=0.7))
247
248         ax.text(x_pos + length/2, y_pos + width/2,
249                 f'{int(length)}x{int(width)}',
250                 ha='center', va='center',
251                 fontsize=8, weight='bold')
252
253     ax.set_xlim(0, self.L)
254     ax.set_ylim(0, self.W)
255     ax.set_aspect('equal')
256     ax.set_title(f'Pattern {pattern_idx} (use {usage:.2f}x)',
257                 fontweight='bold')
258     ax.set_xlabel('Length')
259     ax.set_ylabel('Width')
260     ax.grid(True, alpha=0.3)
261
262     for idx in range(n_patterns, len(axes)):
263         axes[idx].axis('off')
264
265     plt.tight_layout()
266
267     if save_path:
268         plt.savefig(save_path, dpi=150, bbox_inches='tight')
269
270     plt.show()
271
272     def print_solution(self, pattern_usage):
273         """Display the cutting plan"""
274         print("=" * 60)
275         print("CUTTING PLAN")
276         print("=" * 60)
277
278         total = 0.0
279         for idx, usage in pattern_usage.items():
280             pattern = self.patterns[idx]
281             print(f"\nPattern {idx} - use {usage:.2f} sheets:")
282             for i, count in enumerate(pattern):
283                 if count > 0:
284                     dims = self.pieces[i]
285                     print(f"    {count}x {dims[0]} x {dims[1]}")
286             total += usage
287
288         print(f"\nTotal sheets (LP): {total:.2f}")
289         print(f"Total sheets (rounded): {int(np.ceil(total))}")
290
291     if __name__ == "__main__":
292         problem = TwoDStockCutting(
293             sheet_length=100,
294             sheet_width=80,
295             piece_demands={
296                 (55, 35): 7,
297                 (45, 35): 8,
298                 (25, 20): 6
299             }
300         )
301
302         obj, patterns = problem.solve(pricing_time_limit=30)
303
304         if patterns:
305             problem.print_solution(patterns)
306             problem.visualize_patterns(patterns)

```

Listing 5.2: 2D Cutting Stock Problem with Column Generation and MILP Pricing

Appendix B: Pattern Visualization Example

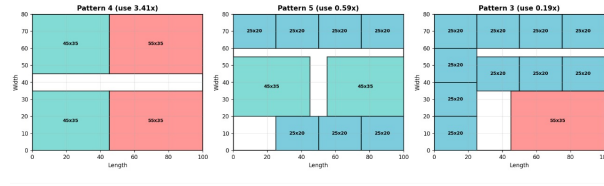


Figure 5.1: DCG Pattern Example 1

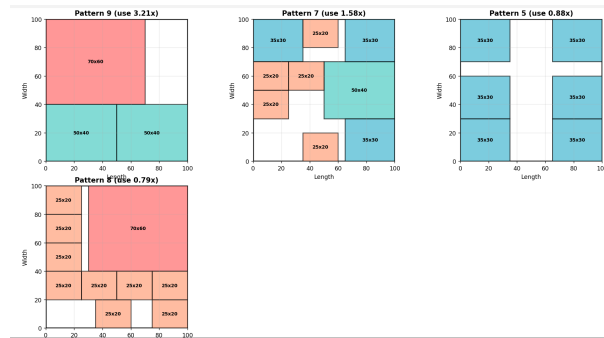


Figure 5.2: DCG Pattern Example 2

Appendix C: Sample Log Output

```
Version identifier: 22.1.1.0 | 2022-11-28 | 9160affd
CPXPARAM_Read DataCheck          1
Legacy callback                    1

Multi-objective solve log . . .

Index Priority Blend      Objective      Nodes Time (sec.) DetTime (ticks)
1          2          1 1.89095000000e+04 336531  644.03    758669.46
Terminated with: Non-optimal status: aborted, feasible
```

Figure 5.3: Log Output Example